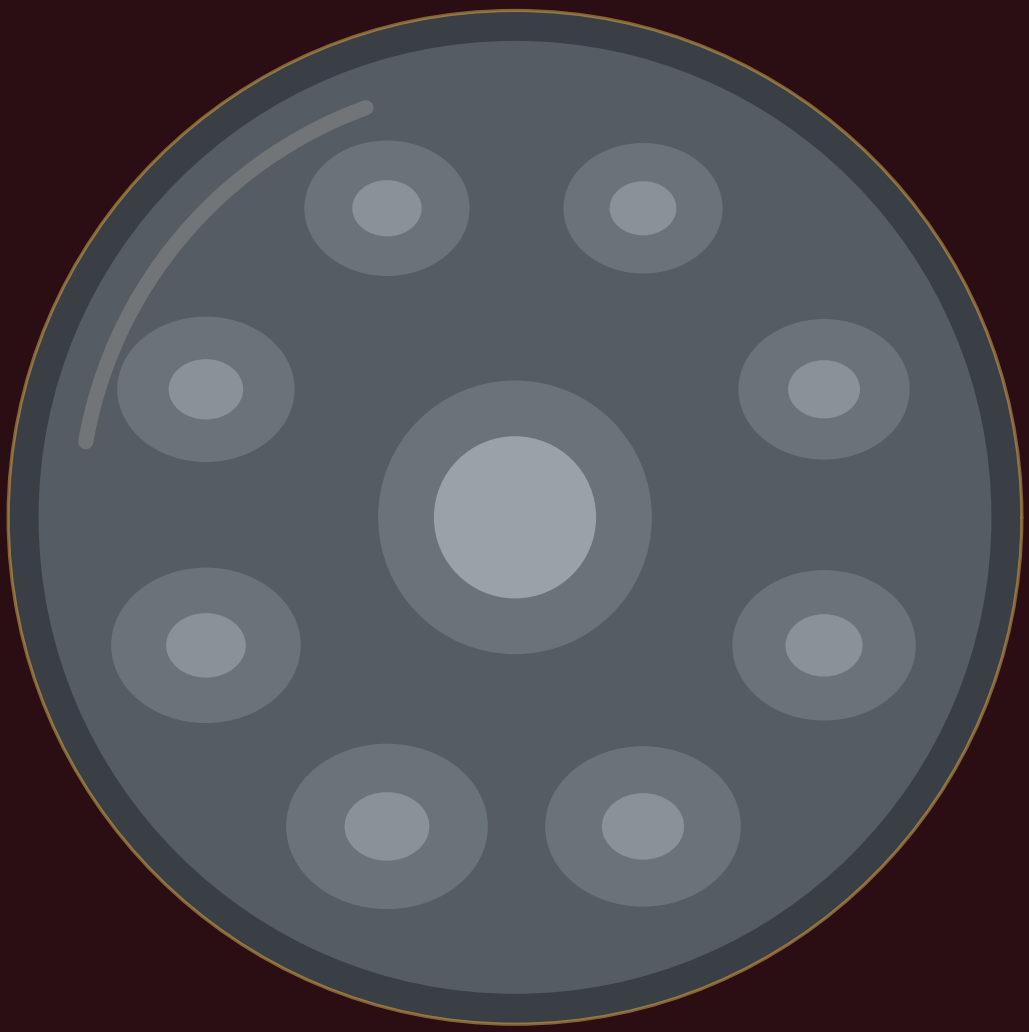
WALAMORT FREE GUIDE

First steps in *handpan*

FREE

Parts, technique, note map, grooves and two melodies.



@Walamort

9-note handpan in G minor

BEFORE YOU START

Welcome

Hi, I'm Walter, Walamort: musician, producer and music teacher in Medellín. This guide is my gift to help you start on handpan. You do not need to read music: everything uses numbers and simple symbols.

In this guide you will learn

- The parts of a handpan and how to care for it.
- Posture and striking technique.
- The note map, from 0 (ding) to 8.
- Rhythm reading and your first grooves.
- Two complete original melodies.

Your tuning

This guide uses a nine-note handpan in G minor: a G ding surrounded by D, E-flat, F, G, A, B-flat, C and D. For other tunings, check the intervals before adapting the numbers; the musical result may change.

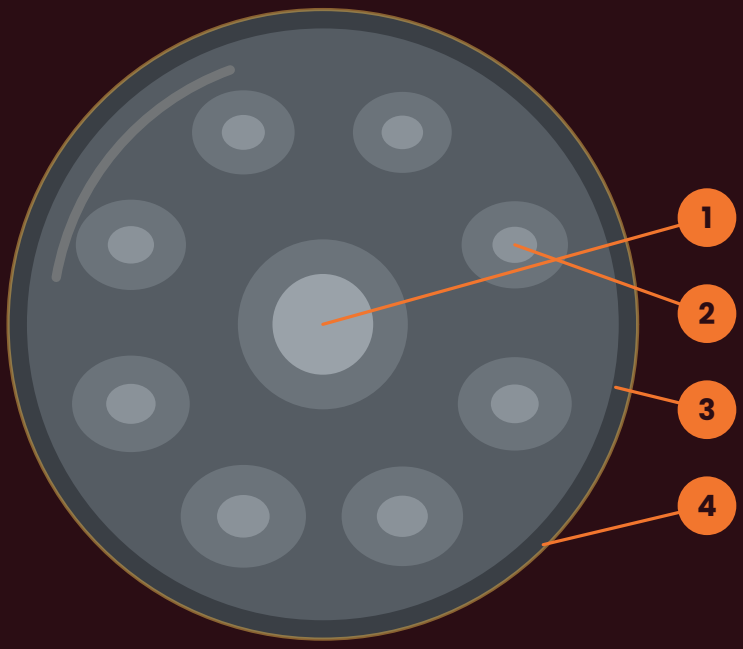
How to use this guide

Read one page daily and practice ten minutes. For questions, contact me via WhatsApp or Instagram @Walamort.

MEET THE INSTRUMENT

Parts of your handpan

A handpan is made of two steel half-shells joined at the rim. The top carries the notes; the bottom has an opening that resonates like a bottle's mouth, adding depth to the sound.



1 Ding

The center and lowest note: the scale's home base.

2 Tone fields

The notes around the ding. Each has a small dome in its center.

3 Shoulder

The smooth area between fields. Play tak, the percussive strike, here.

4 Rim

A joint of the two half-shells. Protect it from impacts.

Underneath: the gu

The lower shell has an opening called the gu. A palm strike produces a deep bass sound; covering and uncovering it while a note rings changes its color. Do not rest the gu on hard surfaces: the instrument may scratch or lose tuning.

Hang or handpan?

The Hang was the first instrument of this type, created in Switzerland in 2000 by PANArt. Handpan is the general name now used for this family of instruments.

Posture and playing position

Where to place it

On your lap. Sit upright with knees together and the handpan resting on them, ding facing you.

On a stand or ring. Useful for standing or long sessions. The gu stays clear, giving a more open sound.

On a cushion on the floor. Comfortable, but it dampens some bass. Never place it directly on tile.

How to strike

1. **Use your finger pads**
   Strike with the pad of your index or middle finger, or several fingers together. Nails and rings can scratch the steel.

2. **A short, bouncing strike**
   Strike and lift the finger immediately, as if the surface were hot. Leaving your finger on it dampens the note.

3. **Aim at the tone field's center**
   The clearest sound comes near the central dome, not the field's edge.

4. **Use little force**
   The handpan responds to gentle touches. Hard strikes can damage its tuning rather than improve the sound.

The tak

Tap the shoulder between tone fields with a fingertip or the soft pads of several fingers. Its dry, unpitched sound plays the snare's role in a groove.

READING THE HANDPAN

The note map

The notes use numbers: 0 is the ding; 1 to 8 are the tone fields, from lowest to highest. They zigzag, with odd numbers on the left and even numbers on the right.



Numbers = notes

0 G (ding) · 1 D · 2 Eb · 3 F · 4 G · 5 A · 6 Bb · 7 C · 8 D

Playing hand

Left: 1, 3, 5 and 7. Right: 2, 4, 6 and 8. Ding and tak: whichever hand is free.

G minor (Kurd) gives you notes from one scale to explore together. If your handpan has another tuning, check its intervals before reusing these numbers; a different scale changes the melodies' color and sometimes their shape.

WALAMORT NOTATION

How to read rhythm

Each box equals one beat, the steady pulse you might tap with your foot. Bar lines group beats into bars: most pieces here use four beats, while some use three, like a waltz.

0 **Ding**
The center note. Play it with your thumb or several fingers together.

4 **Number**
A tone field, from 1 (lowest) to 8 (highest).

T **Tak**
A dry, unpitched shoulder strike: the handpan's snare sound.

— **Dash**
Let the previous note ring for one more beat without striking again.

· **Rest**
One beat without playing. Count it just like the others.

| **Bar line**
The end of a bar. Start counting again from one.

How to count

Count aloud as you play. In four beats: one, two, three, four. In three beats: one, two, three.

EXAMPLE



Use a metronome

Download a free metronome app and start at 60 beats per minute. After playing a piece correctly three times in a row, increase to 70, then 80. A relaxed pace suits the handpan better than rushing.

RHYTHM

Your first grooves

A groove is a repeating rhythm pattern. On handpan, the ding acts as a kick drum and the tak as a snare. Repeat each groove until you can play without looking at your hands.

Groove 1 · Heartbeat

4 BEATS

Alternate ding and tak: a foundation for many patterns.



Groove 2 · March

4 BEATS

One ding and three taks. Keep the taks soft and even.



Groove 3 · Waltz

3 BEATS

Count one, two, three. The ding always lands on one.



Groove 4 · Journey

4 BEATS

Ding on one and a different note on three.



Tip

Once a groove feels automatic, sing an invented melody over it. This trains your brain to separate rhythm from melody, an important handpan skill.

Two melodies to get started

First Heartbeat

ORIGINAL PIECE

The ding marks each bar; the melody rises and returns to G.

0 — 4 — | 0 — 5 — | 0 — 6 — | 5 — 4 —

0 — 4 — | 0 — 5 — | 0 — 3 — | 4 — — —

Staircase

ORIGINAL PIECE

Climb the zigzag step by step and rest on the long notes.

1 2 3 4 | 5 — 4 — | 3 4 5 6 | 7 — 6 —

5 6 7 8 | 7 6 5 4 | 3 2 3 1 | 0 — — —

KEEP IT SOUNDING FOR YEARS

Caring for your handpan

The handpan is sturdy, but its tuning depends on the steel keeping its shape. These habits help keep it tuned and free from rust.

- Wipe with a dry microfiber cloth after playing: sweat can cause rust.
- Each month, apply a very thin layer of protective oil suitable for your instrument and wipe away excess; follow the maker's care guidance.
- Do not leave it in direct sun, a hot car or unprotected near the beach: heat and salt can damage it.
- Store in its padded case, upright or face down on a soft surface.
- Avoid impacts from hard objects; do not play wearing rings or with long nails.

Out of tune?

If a note sounds out of tune or buzzes, do not repair it yourself. Handpan tuning requires specialist tools and experience. Contact the maker or a professional tuner.

Before playing

Wash and dry your hands thoroughly. Clean hands help your sound and protect the instrument.

WHAT COMES NEXT?

You have taken your first steps.

Keep the music going.

Enjoyed it? Continue with the Walamort handpan method: three levels with study plans, 18 original pieces, chords, Latin rhythms, improvisation and composition. Find it at walamort.com.

Method by level

Beginner COP 24,900 · Intermediate COP 29,900 · Advanced COP 34,900 · Three-level pack COP 69,900.

Online lessons

Personalized video-call lessons, wherever you live. Book at walamort.com.

A new instrument every week

Its history, interesting facts, a beat made with its sounds and the song you choose.

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